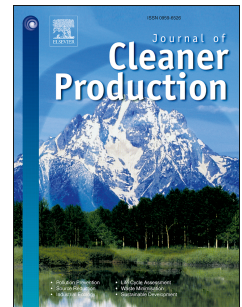


Accepted Manuscript

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology: A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Liisa Haapanen, Petri Tapio



PII: S0959-6526(15)01408-0

DOI: [10.1016/j.jclepro.2015.10.024](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jclepro.2015.10.024)

Reference: JCLP 6255

To appear in: *Journal of Cleaner Production*

Received Date: 2 December 2014

Revised Date: 1 October 2015

Accepted Date: 6 October 2015

Please cite this article as: Haapanen L, Tapio P, Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology: A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique, *Journal of Cleaner Production* (2015), doi: 10.1016/j.jclepro.2015.10.024.

This is a PDF file of an unedited manuscript that has been accepted for publication. As a service to our customers we are providing this early version of the manuscript. The manuscript will undergo copyediting, typesetting, and review of the resulting proof before it is published in its final form. Please note that during the production process errors may be discovered which could affect the content, and all legal disclaimers that apply to the journal pertain.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology: A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Liisa Haapanen^a and Petri Tapio^b (corresponding author)

a:

Department of Environmental Sciences
University of Helsinki
P.O. Box 65 (Viikinkaari 1),
00014 University of Helsinki
FINLAND

email: liisa.haapanen@iki.fi.

phone: +358 50 409 6595

Research Group FIDEA (www.fidea.fi)

b:

Finland Futures Research Centre
Turku School of Economics
FI-20014 University of Turku
FINLAND.

email: petri.tapio@utu.fi

phone: +358 40 555 2963

Research Group FIDEA (www.fidea.fi)

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology: A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Abstract. The concept of degrowth has refuelled the criticism of unchecked economic growth. The purpose of this paper is to identify the central themes of the 21st century growth critique. Qualitative content analysis is conducted for three contemporary classics of the expanding degrowth literature: Peter Victor's *Managing without growth: Slower by design, not disaster*, Serge Latouche's *Farewell to Growth* and Tim Jackson's *Prosperity without growth: Economics for a finite planet*. The analysis reveals three central themes, which provide different perspectives on growth: 1) Growth as a phenomenon, focusing on the forms and impacts of growth and degrowth; 2) Growth as an institution, investigating institutions that either support or depend on growth; 3) Growth as an ideology, perceiving economic growth as an overwhelming and hegemonic political goal above other goals and the need for emancipation. The themes complement each other. Together they provide a new framework for understanding the diverse aspects of growth and degrowth. The analysis shows that the growth critique is essentially a critique of growth societies, not only a critique of GDP growth and that the growth critics are more elaborate in describing what they oppose than what they support. An inner tension within growth critique regarding attitudes to agrowth and degrowth is also revealed.

Keywords: economic growth, degrowth, qualitative content analysis

Highlights:

1. A qualitative content analysis was conducted on three books representing the 21st century growth critique.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

2. The analysis revealed three themes: economic growth as a phenomenon, an institution and an ideology.

3. The first theme focuses on the forms and impacts of growth and degrowth.

4. The second theme emphasises the institutional structures that either support or are dependent on growth.

5. The third theme views growth as a hegemonic political goal set above other goals.

1 Introduction

The purpose of this paper is to identify and analyse the central themes of the contemporary growth critique. Earlier debates on the volume of material production and consumption in the economy are well-established. Malthus started the discussion about the discrepancy between the growth rates of population and food production as early as two hundred years ago (Malthus 1976). Economic growth became the main goal of public policies especially in the USA in the decades after World War II (Collins 2002). As a reaction, the divergence of economic growth and well-being was discussed elaborately. Galbraith (1958) considered the American standard of living in the 1950s so high that increasing consumption was no longer based on satisfying the needs, but on creating artificial wants. On the basis of his empirical studies, Easterlin (1974) questioned the assumption that general happiness of a nation would increase indefinitely and suggested that saturation would be reached at a certain income level (see also Max-Neef 1995). A number of explanations for saturation and/or the negative well-being effects of economic growth were introduced: for example, status consumption as a zero sum game (Hirsch 1977) and consumption as a source of comfort, as opposed to pleasure and joy (Scitovsky 1977).

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Publishing the *Limits to Growth* (Meadows et al. 1972) computer simulations and the simultaneous oil crisis in 1973–74 brought resource scarcity and the ideas of planetary boundaries of economic growth to international attention (Boulding 1968; Georgescu-Roegen 1971; Collins 2002). The idea of the steady-state economy was introduced and developed further by Daly who envisioned stopping the growth of material production and consumption (1996, 1991, and 1974).¹ Also, the field of ecological economics was established to take into account the material and energy flows between natural and human economies (Røpke 2004). In the 1980s, the concept of sustainable development rose to the international agenda after the publication of *Our Common Future* (WCED 1987). In this vastly influential book, sustainable development was considered to be realised through economic growth in the developing countries, whereas in the developed countries it would be achieved by increased efficiency in food and energy production, reallocation of wealth, and sustainable maintenance of natural resources.

According to Mitcham (1995) sustainable development was from the beginning an attempt to reconcile economic growth with the demands for ecological integrity (see also Carruthers 2001; Mebratu 1998). Interpreting sustainable development as sustainable growth has become mainstream thinking in the official national and international political arenas. At the same time growth critique has landed in a marginal position (Carruthers 2001; see also Fuchs and Lorek 2005). The signs of marginalisation can be seen, for example, in the Agenda 21 adopted in 1992 at Rio Earth Summit (UN 1993) and the relatively modest attention given to the elaborately updated *Limits to Growth* book (Meadows et al 1992; 2004). Growth critical aspects are clearly missing in the report of the Rio+20 Conference in 2012 (UNEP 2011). The tendency to strongly emphasise the potential of eco-efficiency while ignoring or even denying

¹ See also Kerschner (2010) on the complementarity of degrowth and steady-state.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

the possibility of curbing Western consumption prevails in the official environmental agenda. The latest buzzwords, such as 'green economy' and 'green (economic) growth' (European Commission 2011; OECD 2011; UNEP 2011), follow this line of thought and can be regarded as synonyms for 'sustainable growth.'

Recently, the debate on degrowth has fuelled the renaissance of criticism of unchecked economic growth. Degrowth draws from earlier growth critique, especially that of Georgescu-Roegen; however, according Demaria et al. (2013), it has various other intellectual sources too. Martínez-Alier et al. (2010) describe degrowth as a grassroots movement and an academic concept that influence each other. Demaria et al. (2013) also use the term 'activist-led science.' Schneider et al. (2010) define sustainable degrowth as 'an equitable down-scaling of production and consumption that increases human well-being and enhances ecological conditions at the local and global level, in the short and long term.' They also distinguish sustainable degrowth from unsustainable degrowth, that is, recession and depression. According to Fournier (2008), degrowth attempts to repoliticise economics and emphasises equality, democracy and citizenship (see also Demaria et al. 2013).

The purpose of this paper is to analyse the themes in the classics of contemporary growth critique. The research question is 'What kind of themes can be defined from the central publications?' The question is divided into four subquestions: 1) What kinds of meanings are attached to economic growth? 2) What, precisely, is it in economic growth that is being criticised? 3) What kind of forms does the opposition between defenders and critics of growth take? 4) What do the growth critics offer as an alternative to economic growth? The main focus of this article is to answer the first two questions. Questions 3 and 4 are treated only from the perspective of illustrating how different forms of opposition and the various

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

propositions of growth critics can be positioned within the identified themes. That is to say, questions 3 and 4 are answered in a short and summarising manner and the purpose of this article is not to provide a comprehensive and detailed description of these topics.

Section 2 presents the material and methods are introduced. The three core themes identified in the material are presented in sections 3, 4 and 5. Finally, the findings are summarised and discussed in section 6.

2 Materials and Methods

A survey of approximately 30 recent scientific articles related to growth critique in general and to degrowth in particular revealed that quite a few of them referred to works of three authors – Tim Jackson, Serge Latouche and Peter Victor – and especially to some of their latest books. These books were *Managing without growth: Slower by design, not disaster* (Victor 2009), *Farewell to Growth* (Latouche 2009; French original *Petit traité de la décroissance sereine*, published 2006), and *Prosperity without growth: Economics for a finite planet* (Jackson 2009). The material of this study comprises these three books, which we regard as contemporary classics of growth critique.² Jackson's book contains short commentaries by Herman Daly, Bill McKibben, Mary Robinson and Pavan Sukhdev; these texts were included in the analysis. Since the material represents only growth critique,³ the perspectives of the growth advocates are beyond the scope of this paper.

² In order to make the text more readable, references to the three books that constitute the research material are indicated by author name and pagination only (no publication year). For example, (Jackson 39) refers to Jackson's *Prosperity without Growth*, page 39. All other references are indicated with publication year as usual.

³ Latouche has actively participated in the formation of the degrowth concept. Jackson and Victor do not identify themselves within degrowth in their books. Thus we prefer to use the umbrella term 'growth critique' instead of the more specific term 'degrowth' when referring to the entire research material.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

In order to answer the research question, a qualitative content analysis (Elo and Kyngäs 2008; Forman and Damschroder 2008; Graneheim and Lundman 2004;) was conducted on the material. This method can be used to identify the central themes from a text mass. First, the key meanings and content of the selected meaning units are summarised in a compact form. The term 'meaning unit' refers to the words, sentences or paragraphs of the text. Since the material contains of approximately 600 pages of text, the analysis concentrates mainly on the paragraph level in order to avoid fragmentation. Selecting the relevant meaning units was guided by the research questions. The next step of the analysis was to arrange and group the condensed meaning units hierarchically into sub- and supragroups. At the same time, the meanings were condensed (and abstracted) further in order to identify the core content.

The qualitative content analysis can be focused on the manifest and/or latent contents of the text. These content types require a varying degree of interpretation, with manifest contents being more obvious and latent contents more ambiguous. Graneheim and Lundman (2004) suggest that the terms 'category' and 'theme' should be used to refer to manifest and latent contents, respectively. The terminology used in this study follows this suggestion, as it provides transparency with regard to the stage in which interpretation and abstraction begin to dominate the analysis. According to Graneheim and Lundman, categories are mutually exclusive whereas themes are not, because latent contents are open to multiple interpretations.

The analysis ensures that economic growth is addressed more broadly than simply in terms of GDP growth. Essentially, growth critique is a critique of growth societies, covering not only economic activity but also a wide range of social phenomena and political processes.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

There are several ways to distinguish between different aspects of growth. In the research material, Latouche proposes a distinction between growth 'as [an] evolutionary phenomenon[on] affecting specific realities (population, potato production, quantities of waste, toxicity of water, etc.)' and 'as [an] abstract concept referring to an economic dynamism that is an end in itself.' Spangenberg (2010) differentiates between growth and growth policy, since they have different effects. Kerschner (2010) distinguishes three aspects of growth: growth discourse as a driving force, growth policy as a pressure, and the real impacts of economic growth. In contrast to these proposals, the suggestion put forward in this paper is based on a qualitative content analysis of degrowth literature. As a result of the analysis, three central themes in the 21st century growth critique were identified from the material: growth as a phenomenon, growth as an institution and growth as an ideology. Each theme offers a different point of view to economic growth and to the research questions. In the following sections, these themes are presented separately.

3 Growth as Phenomenon

'The myth of growth has failed us. It has failed the 1 billion people who still attempt to live on half the price of a cup of coffee each day. It has failed the fragile ecological systems on which we depend for survival.' (Jackson 15)

The first theme examined is 'growth as a phenomenon' which deals with the concrete consequences of economic growth. From this point of view, the critique is targeted towards the growing negative effects and decreasing positive effects of economic growth. Jackson and, especially, Victor put a lot of effort into building their case by using a set of indicators. In Latouche's book, the problematic nature of economic growth is the starting point rather than the conclusion.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

The consequences of economic growth discussed in the books fall into two categories: environmental effects and well-being effects. When examining the environmental effects of economic growth, the authors concentrate on the negative effects. The possibility of positive effects – as described in the environmental Kuznets curve hypothesis (see e.g. Ang and Liu 2006; Ayres 2008; Munasinghe 1996;) – is only briefly touched upon by Jackson (76) and Victor (164–5). They argue that the hypothesis holds true only for the local and easily-remedied problems. What is more, Victor considers that technical solutions to local problems sometimes contribute to global ecological crisis.

Latouche (e.g. 23–5, 33) discusses environmental problems on a general level using the comprehensive term ‘environmental crisis’ and referring mostly to the ecological footprint. Jackson (6–14, 32–33, 67–86) and Victor (47–123), on the other hand, are more specific and consider environmental problems from the viewpoint of resource scarcity, sinks and life-supporting ecosystem services. According to Jackson and Victor, these three together impose biophysical limits on growth. Violation of these limits is seen as a threat to long-term sustainability and to the possibility of future generations to flourish (Latouche 23–5, 31; Jackson 32–33, 45; Victor 43–44, 47).

When referring to past and currently occurring environmental problems, the authors most often simply state that economic growth is their main cause (e.g. Daly in Jackson 267; Jackson 13, 121; Victor 98). However, when considering the future, the argumentation becomes more refined and elaborate. Jackson (77–82) and Victor (102–23) utilise the IPAT equation (see York et al. 2003 and Waggoner and Ausubel 2002 for IPAT in general). Victor (99–123) also discerns the scale, composition and technology of the economy. Thus, it

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

becomes clear that the volume of the economy is not the only factor behind ecological distress.

The key question here is whether environmental problems can significantly be ameliorated by technological means while sustaining economic growth. In other words, is absolute decoupling possible? Jackson (67–86) and Victor (54–59, 70, 173–6) make a distinction between absolute and relative decoupling (a more refined distinction is provided by Tapio 2005). In absolute decoupling, environmental impacts decline even if the economy grows. Relative decoupling indicates a situation where the environmental impacts still grow, but the economy grows faster. Since the environmental impacts are already on an unsustainable level, absolute decline is needed. Jackson and Victor raise two questions in regard to absolute decoupling.

Firstly, is absolute decoupling already occurring? Jackson (67–86) and Victor (54–59, 70, 107–123) deny this (see also Bithas and Kalimeris 2013 on the global aggregate level of decoupling). Jackson mentions certain Western countries where the growth of environmental impacts has levelled off despite rising GDP. He points out that this improvement is more apparent than real, however, because these countries have externalised production and environmental problems to the Third World (Jackson 73–75, 129; see also empirical evidence in Mattila 2011 and Peters et al. 2011).

Secondly, is absolute decoupling probable in future? Again, the answers provided by Jackson (14, 68–86, 121–2, 187–8) and Victor (107–123, 173–6) are negative since the actual improvement rates in eco-efficiency comprise only a fraction of the required rates. They conclude that absolute decoupling is a myth, an unattainable technological dream. Thus, they reject the highly popular vision of green growth, arguing that there is an inescapable

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

contradiction between continuous growth and environmental protection (see also Latouche 11, 55–6). According to Jackson (95) and Victor (110–1), the rebound effect will undermine the potential of technological solutions even further.⁴ They conclude that, alongside technological improvements, the scale of the economy has to be addressed as well.⁵

The social effects of economic growth are also discussed in the books. While recognising the suffering caused by the inability to meet one's basic needs, Latouche is sceptical about the benefits of economic growth and the whole concept of progress (16–20, 52–65). Jackson and Victor, for their part, examine the subject in a more detailed and broad manner than Latouche. They use statistical data and compare GDP to more specific welfare indicators. Jackson and Victor do not deny the past achievements of economic growth in improving health, prolonging human life, etc., but they also remind that the problems of poverty and inequality as well as unemployment persist in spite of economic growth. Jackson (55–62) also points out that, statistically, some middle and low income countries rank remarkably high in one or more basic components of well-being, thus suggesting that the causal relationship between income and well-being is not clear and constant. What is more, Jackson (5, 40–42, 50–65) and Victor (124–68, 129–133) conclude that economic growth has long since ceased to increase well-being and happiness of Western people. Jackson (40–41)

⁴ On different definitions and estimates of the rebound effect see e.g. Berkhout et al. (2000), Binswanger (2011) and Greening et al. (2000). Alfredsson (2004) has conducted an interesting empirical study on green consumption and its rebound effect in Swedish households. Alcott (2010 and 2008) and Figge et al. (2014) discuss the occurrence of rebound effects in the context of sufficiency, and Schneider (2008) analyses the concept in the context of degrowth.

⁵ In contrast, none of the authors suggest controlling population growth as a means to relieve environmental pressures. The books refer to the morally problematic nature of influencing fertility rates and take the estimated population growth as a given. Jackson (77), however, implies that also high fertility rates can be morally problematic if they are not based on freedom of choice. Latouche (25–29) regards the reduction of population as 'a false solution.' He argues that the humanity should first tackle the problems of excess consumption and inequitable distribution of resources, and only after that can the population issue be addressed calmly and rationally. In contrast, Victor (24, 194) states that a socially sustainable non-growing economy would also require a non-growing population (see also Kerschner 2010). Nevertheless, Victor does not propose any measures for controlling fertility rates. This is due to the fact that he treats mostly the case of Canada, in which fertility rates are already low and the population is ageing. Thus, Victor suggests only minor alterations to the Canadian policy of work-related immigration.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

and Victor (126) both refer to a level of approximately \$15,000 GDP per capita after which increases in GDP hardly contribute to well-being (see also Max-Neef 1995). As Victor ironically states, North Americans and the West in general 'have been more successful in decoupling GDP from happiness than in decoupling it from material and energy' (125).

Explanations for this divergence between well-being or happiness and economic growth are manifold, and the following summary does not do justice to the richness of detail in the research material. Victor and Jackson delve into this subject more explicitly and systematically. Firstly, Jackson (40–41, 55–61) appeals to the diminishing marginal utility of rising incomes and economic growth, that is, the fact that the benefits of incremental growth decrease while the costs increase (see also Daly in Jackson 268). In addition, all three authors refer to negative well-being effects of growth, such as stress, unrewarding work, and weakening communities and social relations (Jackson 101, 144, 147–8; Latouche 16–20, 54, 81–88; Victor 154). Secondly, Jackson (39–40, 125–6, 179–80) and Victor (9–10, 129–31) mention the well-known criticisms of GDP as a measure of well-being, such as the inclusion of aspects that decrease well-being; the exclusion of factors that increase well-being; and lack of attention paid to income distribution; (see also van den Bergh 2010 and 2009; Giannetti 2015). Thirdly, the books discuss the idea of people getting used to a higher standard of living and adjusting their aspirations accordingly (Jackson 41; Victor 127). This type of adaptation also explains why a reduction in the current levels of Western consumption would result in a (temporary) feeling of deprivation even if basic needs were still met (see e.g. Matthey 2010). The fourth argument is, in brief, that happiness and contentment are partly affected by the relative status and position, especially after the basic needs are met. A rise in the overall standard of living does not affect relative positions; however, the questions of income

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

distribution and inequality remain significant. (Jackson 50–55, 146–8; Latouche 37; Victor 131–51.)

Nevertheless, Victor (18, 24–5, 98) and Jackson (40–41) believe that non-Western countries would still benefit from economic growth. In fact, one of Victor's (vi, 98, 111–2, 223) main proposals is that, in a world with limits to growth, the Western countries should abandon growth in order to make room for other regions' economies to grow. They argue that, in these countries, the standard of living is still comparatively low, which means that the marginal utility is higher and the threshold after which rising incomes cease to contribute to well-being has not been reached yet. Victor, however, is doubtful of emphasising growth over equality. In other words, he implicitly raises the question of how the benefits of non-Western growth would and should be shared. Latouche (56–65), instead, warns against the perils of growth-dependency and Westernization, encouraging the people of the Third World to create and strive for their own visions of success and well-being.

From the perspective of growth as phenomenon, the overall conclusion of the books is that, in the Western countries, the negative effects of economic growth override the positive ones. This is aptly summarised by Herman Daly in the commentary of Jackson's book (268): we 'have entered an era of uneconomic growth.'

Under the phenomenon theme, the controversy between the critics and the defenders of economic growth revolves around the true and correct interpretations of empirical data on well-being, environmental effects, and eco-efficiency brought about by technological advancements, with both sides of the controversy contesting for the most convincing arguments (see also Daly 1997; Solow 1997; Stiglitz 1997). The information and data about the effects of economic growth is plentiful, fragmented, and open to multiple interpretations.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Thus, the critics rather successfully convince the reader that those believing in sustainable growth might be wrong. The question is, however, can they convince the reader that they themselves are right?

According to the authors, concentrating on economic growth results in losing focus on the things that really matter. Instead of striving for overall economic growth, all three books make a case for more precisely defined social and ecological goals (Jackson 122, 194; Latouche 13; Victor 2, 184). They argue that if these goals are achieved, it should not matter whether the economy grows or diminishes. Thus, the authors promote a nonchalant attitude towards the size of the economy, that is, 'agrowth' (e.g. Jackson 141, 197; Latouche 8; Victor 1, 184.) Recently, there has been a debate on whether one should resist the centrality of economic growth explicitly or adopt the agrowth approach (see Kallis 2011; van den Bergh 2011; van den Bergh and Kallis 2012).

In addition, none of the three authors condemn all growth. They support the idea of downsizing the areas of economic activity that are negative for the nature and the well-being of humans, while sustaining or even growing the positive ones (e.g. Latouche 80–1, 84). Thus, they promote the principle of selectivity. Unfortunately, this alternative is not described very clearly. Which activity is good and which is bad? What will happen when the negative ones are reduced? Are the good ones actually functional substitutes for the bad ones? The qualitative content analysis of the phenomenon theme is summarised in Table 1.

Table 1. Key elements of the phenomenon's theme are summarized in the table. The first stage of the analysis is on the left column, the second stage in the centre and the final stage on right.

Condensed meaning	Category	Theme
-------------------	----------	-------

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Formerly economic growth increased well-being in the Western countries, it can continue to do so in the non-Western countries	Social and well-being effects of economic growth	Economic growth as a phenomenon with concrete ecological and social consequences
No link between well-being and economic growth in the Western countries anymore		
Increasing malaise as a result of economic growth		
Increasing negative environmental effects	Environmental effects of economic growth	
Economic growth and reduction of negative environmental impacts cannot be combined		
No significant positive environmental effects		

4 Growth as Institution

‘It is not difficult to imagine the catastrophes that negative growth would bring about! Just as there is nothing worse than a work-based society in which there is no work, there is nothing worse than a growth-based society in which growth does not materialise.’ (Latouche 8)

The second theme identified in the material is economic growth as an institution. All three authors state that institutions based on economic growth, either requiring or boosting growth, are ubiquitous in modern societies. Especially Jackson (e.g. 87–102, 131–3, 151–3, 184) studies this dynamics in his book. The notion of institution refers to socially shared rules, norms and habits that coordinate actions of individuals and groups (Ostrom 2005: 3–31; Scott 2008: 47–78; Vatn 2005: 1–86, 169–191). Institutions assign individuals and groups into different roles that enable and restrict their actions. Institutions connect rewards and punishments to different actions. They also influence how much and what kind of information is available in different roles. This way the institutions direct and control behaviour, but do not determine it.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

In coordination or interest conflicts, institutions regularise actions by cementing one solution out of many options. They also shape people's expectations towards each other's behaviour. Institutions are made by humans and need to be actively reproduced. This also opens up a possibility of changing them. (Ibid.)

One aspect of institutions related to economic growth is growth-dependency. According to the three authors, the stability of societies and some parts of well-being – especially employment and the livelihoods of people – are currently dependent on economic growth (Jackson 13–15, 16–17, 61–5, 133–6; Latouche 3, 7–9, 76–88; Victor 12–3, 155–8, 222). The books conclude that societies are addicted to growth: there is always a demand for more, no matter how large the economy is already (Jackson 25, Latouche 16). All three books deal with the basic macroeconomic relation between technical development and employment (Jackson 63, 133–6; Latouche 76–81; Victor 12–3⁶, 155–8, 172). When productivity is improved, the same output can be produced with fewer workers. Hence, in order to avoid unemployment, the economic output must be continually expanded. Victor (169–183) adds a third piece to this treadmill: funding for public welfare services is based on income and consumption taxes and is, thus, linked to economic growth. Also, unemployment burdens the public economy in the form of unemployment compensations. Ceasing to improve one's own productivity does not entail serene stability but falling behind, since everybody else is striving for more productivity. Both firms and nation-states are bound to a productivity race. According to Victor (1, 18–19), growth advocates consider productivity, competitiveness and economic growth synonyms.

⁶ Victor (4–22) examines the institutional and ideological aspects of economic growth. He cites H.W. Arndt's (1978) book *The Rise and Fall of Economic Growth* frequently and extensively. Arndt describes how, after World War II, economic growth was adopted as central remedy to unemployment and other macroeconomic problems, and eventually became a top priority of economic policy. He also examines how growth critique followed (and even coevolved with) the triumph of growth.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Jackson (61–5) also calls attention to modern economies' internal feedback mechanisms which intensify economic fluctuations. In a recession, consumers' trust dwindles and they restrain their spending. The same holds true for companies which put off investments. This results in a decreasing demand, which forces companies to lay off their employees. The unemployed can consume less, which further cuts down demand. This leads to 'a spiral of recession' (Jackson 63). In an economic upswing the mechanism works in the opposite direction resulting in a boom period. According to Jackson (64–5, 128), all this leads to 'a dilemma of growth': growth is unsustainable due to its increasing negative effects, while, on the other hand, degrowth would lead to instability under present conditions.

Another aspect of institutions related to economic growth is sustenance of growth, of which the books present a range of examples. Jackson (86, 111–4, 117–9, 129–41) and Victor (155, 204) describe how governments have opted for productivity and economic growth over long term social and environmental sustainability in order to push away the short-term threat of recession and societal hardship. Latouche (67–8) shares this notion, pointing out that '[a]ll governments are, whether they like it or not, capital's "functionaries".' In other words, the authors argue that politics has become an institution for maintaining economic growth.

The loan market is another example of an institution that sustains economic growth (Jackson 21–30; Latouche 18; see also van Griethuysen 2010). The availability of consumer debt allows people to disentangle their consumption level from their income level. On the other hand, loan interests oblige people to work more in order to pay back the loan in the future. (Ibid.) Also the price system is described as an institution supporting economic growth (Latouche 19, 31, 73; Victor 39–46). Many negative effects of production and consumption are

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

not reflected in prices but are externalities,⁷ which makes the production and consumption of many goods and services artificially profitable (Latouche 19, 31; see also Schor 2005). Since profits are also calculated in a monetary terms, the distorted price system has a significant effect on the business sector. Latouche (17, 19) claims that, in order to maximise and to secure their sales in the future, many companies, for example, use planned obsolescence in their products (see also Baran and Sweezy 1966, 381–384). Decisions based on prices are not well-informed; consequently, according to Latouche (18–19), unethical choices are abundant. Latouche writes provokingly that ‘all capitalists and financiers, as well as any homo economicus (meaning all of us), tend to become ordinary “criminals” who collude to some extent in the economic banality of evil’ (ibid.). The predominant perception of profit and productivity has also its effect on investments. According to Jackson (82–85, 138–140, 197), the prevailing expectations on the rate and period of financial returns discourage the much needed investments on eco-efficiency and ecosystem services since they come across as less profitable. This problem is also discussed by Hoffman (2011).

Another institution supporting economic growth is the consumer culture, which is scrutinised in particular by Jackson (18, 87–102, 146–8, 163–8, 183–4; see also Latouche 16–20, 36–7, 52–6; Victor 35, 127–8, 131–151, 159). The research material depicts a wide range of motives for current consumption patterns and Jackson also examines the dynamics between the consumers and the producers (see also Røpke’s [1999] multifaceted analysis on the reasons behind growing consumption). According to the authors, in the modern consumer culture(s), children are socialised into being consumers from early age on; people are also continuously encouraged to act as consumers, not the least by advertisements (Jackson 191;

⁷ The concept of externalities was introduced by Pigou (1932) and developed further by Kapp (1975). A discussion of externalities in the context of growth critique can be found in Daly and Cobb (1989: 51–8, 141–6).

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Latouche 16–18; Victor 35, 220; see also Schor 2004). The cycle of work-and-spend sets the rhythm of modern life. The concept of work-and-spend cycle comes from Schor, who scrutinises both aspects of the cycle in her seminal books, *The Overworked American* (1993) and *The Overspent American* (1999).

Status consumption is yet another institution fuelling economic growth (Jackson 98–102; Latouche 37; Victor 131–51). The idea of status consumption was introduced as early as 1899 by Veblen (1992) who referred to it as ‘conspicuous consumption.’ Hirsch (1977) developed this concept towards the idea of social limits to growth (see also Schor 1999 for illustrative examples). In the research material, status consumption refers to maintaining and communicating one’s social status by consuming products which are culturally considered prestigious. Status consumption is based on social comparison and it is a zero sum game: when some people manage to climb up the social ladder, the others end up below them. The privileged consumers buy novel and luxury items to signify status. As mass production begins, however, these items become cheaper and more widely available. In time, they become mundane products which only the poorest lack, and, thus, *not* owning them becomes a sign of being a dropout. Both Jackson (147–8) and Victor (159) refer to the idea originating from Adam Smith that there is a culturally bound minimum level of consumption required if an individual is to lead a ‘life without shame.’ In a society committed to economic growth, this standard is continuously rising.

Besides status competition, consumption has other functions as well, for example, symbolic and communicative (Jackson 98–101). Products and services are used to express personality and to construct identity. Jackson (100) refers to McCracken (1988) according to whom consumption is a means to dream and to aspire to a better self (image). In the end,

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

1 however, the products will fail us, but they do so in such a subtle manner that it only leaves us
2 desiring yet another product (ibid).

3 It is striking that the description of the national level productivity competition and the
4 individual level status competition are so similar in the research material. This similarity
5 suggests that they are different manifestations of the same logic. The common denominator is
6 that both types of competition fuel economic growth. All three authors describe this dynamics
7 as ‘a hellish circle,’ ‘a treadmill’ and ‘an iron cage,’ since it just makes people run ever faster in
8 order to stay at the same spot (e.g. Jackson 87, 97; Latouche 3, 16–7, 33, 64, 83; Victor 216).
9 These institutions hardly increase well-being. In fact, they might even be detrimental to well-
10 being since they require so much time, effort and resources which could be better used
11 elsewhere (see Schultz and Tapio 2011).

12 From the perspective of the institution theme, the opposition between the advocates
13 and the opponents of growth appears as a contradiction between reformists and radicals (see
14 also Fournier 2008; Gabriel and Lang 1995: 165–7, 172). While both sides acknowledge the
15 need for change, the difference is that the reformists call for the changes to occur within the
16 current institutions, whereas the radicals promote replacing the institutions themselves. The
17 growth advocates emphasise that abandoning growth would lead to a collapse. The growth
18 critics admit that this is true, but only within the current, growth-dependent structures (e.g.
19 Jackson 64; Latouche 8; Victor 178). The growth critics do not promote recession and
20 depression, that is, the absence of growth in a society that is still dependent on growth.
21 Instead, the critics suggest creating a society independent of growth, an idea the growth
22 advocates dismiss as impractical. However, as Fournier (2008) points out, practicality often
23 means a minor disturbance to current unsustainable patterns of behaviour, which hardly

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

1 guarantees sustainability. On the other hand, it should be noted that making an analytical
2 difference between depression and degrowth vision does not guarantee that implementing
3 such a vision wouldn't still induce a depression during the transition process, before all sectors
4 and constituents of the society would be unhooked from growth.

5 One question related to institutional changes is whether degrowth complies with
6 capitalism or not. This subject is addressed in the research material by Jackson (197–202) and
7 Latouche (88–92), as well as in the general degrowth debate (Foster 2011; Hoffman 2011: 13–
8 4; van Griethuysen 2010). Victor does not elaborate on the subject in *Managing without*
9 *growth*. Jackson (197–202) emphasises the different varieties of capitalism, some of which are
10 not necessarily growth-oriented; in addition, there are many forms of ownership. In his view,
11 the prevailing forms of capitalism need to change dramatically, and whether the end result can
12 still be called capitalism is beside the point. To Latouche (88–92), degrowth implies
13 abandoning the capitalist system. However, according to Latouche, a shift to socialism is not
14 the answer, because socialist economies, too, pursue growth. All in all, it seems that the idea
15 of degrowth transcends the capitalism vs. socialism dichotomy of the 20th century (see also
16 Daly and Cobb 1989: 8–18).

17 How could societies get off the hook of growth, then? The suggestions presented here
18 concentrate on a couple of key features. Reducing working hours could be a means to share
19 the work and to fight unemployment. The salaries would decrease, but, on the other hand,
20 leisure time would increase for those currently employed full-time (Jackson 133–6, 180–1;
21 Latouche 38–41, 69–70, 76–88; Victor 211–4; see also D'Alisa and Cattaneo 2013; Nørgård
22 2013). The authors also suggest reducing status consumption. An important means to achieve
23 this is more equal distribution of income (Jackson 153–5; Latouche 36–7; Victor 220). Jackson

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

(138, 177, 197) and Victor (214) suggest redirecting investments to human and natural capital. Jackson (136–141, 209–15) also explores the possibility of changing profit expectations and other conditions of investment. Latouche (70, 85–8) puts forward the idea of ‘producing relational goods,’ such as friendship and knowledge which, if anything, will just increase in quantity and quality along with consumption. Also, a reformulation of economic theories is called for (see e.g. Jackson 123).

Yet, for the authors, degrowth does not represent overthrowing all economic institutions. According to Latouche (91–2) and Jackson (141, 196), institutions such as private property and money could be preserved as long as they do not unite and form another vicious cycle of growth. Regarding the required institutional changes, the idea of social enterprises receives surprisingly little attention in the research material (on social enterprises in the context of degrowth, see e.g. Johanisova et al. 2013). The content analysis of the institution theme is summarised in Table 2.

Table 2. Key elements of the institution theme are summarized in the table. The first stage of analysis is on the left column, the second stage in the centre and the final stage on right.

Condensed meaning	Category	Theme
Stability of society and a part of well-being are built on economic growth	Dependence on economic growth	Economic growth as an institution
Expectations and practices in politics and business lead to choices that maintain economic growth	Society supporting economic growth	
Information provided by the price system leads to choices that maintain economic growth		
Expectations and practices related to consumption lead to choices that maintain economic growth	Consumer culture maintaining economic growth	
People are being increasingly addressed and positioned as consumers		

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Status and productivity competition that maintain economic growth makes individuals, companies and nation-states go around in circles: it takes more and more effort just to stay in the same position	Economic growth as a vicious cycle or treadmill
--	---

5 Growth as Ideology

‘It is difficult, if not impossible, to step outside your own value system and reflect upon it, but that is what I try to do in this book. – – The main value that I want to call in question is the primacy that we in the rich countries give to economic growth as the overriding economic policy objective for government. – – It is the policy objective against which all other proposals must be judged.’ (Victor 1)

The third central theme in the books is economic growth as an ideology, canonised in various discourses that guide our daily practices. The concept of ideology refers to a belief system of a group (Thompson 2001; van Dijk 1998). Ideology can be perceived as a framework of thinking that has impacts on the way its supporters interpret reality. Ideologies usually contain a set of values and criteria for truth, and, thus, they have an effect on what is considered good or bad and true or false. For this reason, ideology legitimates actions taken by the group and its members. The power of ideologies arises at least partly from the fact that they can be internalised and objectified or even unconscious (ibid.). Some ideologies are weak, however, and even the strongest of them can be contested. Ideology is a social phenomenon, and it is often linked with group interests and power relations between groups (van Dijk 1998). Ideologies are closely linked to institutions. According to Van Dijk (1998: 187), institutions are, indeed, practical counterparts of ideologies. Put simply, institutions direct people’s actions, whereas ideologies affect people’s thoughts.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

The three authors examine beliefs related to economic growth. In the growth ideology, growth is the source of all good (Jackson 5, 35–43; Latouche 89–90; Victor 9–10, 93). According to Victor (5), the belief in the benefits of growth is strong even though proof for the benefits is, at best, mixed, which demonstrates society's ideological commitment to growth. Similarly, the absence of economic growth is apparently the ultimate catastrophe (Jackson 61–5; Latouche 8; Victor 9). In the growth ideology, economic growth is also seen as a prerequisite for amending all misfortunes of our time, such as environmental issues (e.g. Victor 93). Only through more economic growth can people 'afford' to take other than economic values into consideration (ibid.). Therefore, other perspectives actually owe their very existence to economic growth. According to Latouche (9–13) and Victor (2, 19–21), the idea of sustainable development has been assimilated into the dogma of economic growth. For Latouche, this means that the concept of sustainable development should be dispensed with completely.

The authors state that, in the growth ideology, economic growth is equated with welfare and even well-being (Jackson 5, 35–43; Victor 9–10, 93). In their opinion, this also affects the idea of what it is to be a human being: people are seen as consumers and accordingly the human needs are satisfied with goods (sic) sold in the market (Jackson 191; Latouche 23). Furthermore, in the growth ideology, scarcity prevails regardless of how high the standard of living is already (Jackson 25; Latouche 16, 35–6; Victor 25; see also Sahlins 2004: 1–4).

The authors describe a set of values considered characteristic to the growth ideology. Economic values and, especially, economic growth are usually prioritised in decision making. Social and ecological perspectives are secondary (Jackson 167–8; Latouche 8; Victor 1–2, 4–21,

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

92). Furthermore, in the growth ideology, economy is often separated from the surrounding social and ecological reality and only those factors that lie inside the economic sphere are taken into consideration (Jackson 126–7, 142; Latouche 14–5; Victor 34–36). The institutions of price system and profit maximizing are practical examples of this principle (Jackson 92; Latouche 18–9; Victor 217). Also, short-term thinking is prevalent: if one had to choose between short-term profits and long-term ecological and social sustainability, the former would mostly be favoured (Jackson 82, 86, 111–4, 117–9, 129–41; Victor 1, 155, 204; see also Hukkinen 1999).

The authors argue that most members of the growth society consider economic growth to be natural and self-evident (Jackson 4, 14, 190; Latouche 3, 12, 89–90; McKibben in Jackson 269–70; Victor 12, 17, 270;). The logic of growth is not only mainstream thinking, but also an overwhelming hegemony (ibid.) that unites political parties from left to right (Latouche 32, 92–4). It is perhaps due to this hegemonic status that the authors cannot quite name their opponent. They sometimes refer to economists, but more often to ‘people’ or even use the pronoun ‘we’ to express the prevalence of the growth ideology. According to Jackson (14; see also Jackson 24; Latouche 3; Victor viii, 24, 193), degrowth activists receive only marginal attention and are usually labelled as ‘crazy, idealistic and revolutionary’ people. That is to say, growth is unquestionable and if someone dares to question it, (s)he will be condemned as being out of touch with reality. The growth ideology presents the pursuit of continuous economic growth as the only viable option for the future and thus narrows down the official politics and even personal views of people (e.g. Jackson 171, 190, 204; Latouche 3, 8–9, 13, 67–8; Victor 12, 233). Thus, the ‘absurdity’ of degrowth stems not from technical or economic infeasibility, but from what people consider possible.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

According to the negative conceptualisation of ideology, ideologies distort the way people see and understand the world and themselves (McLellan 1995: 1, 8; Thompson 2001; van Dijk 1998: 1–2). This line of thought is visible in the rhetoric of the research material: growth ideology is pictured as distorting the reality and concealing the truth (e.g. Jackson 14, 82, 187–8, 190, 203; Latouche 3–4; Victor 217, 220). For example, there are some remarks in the books that the authors' critical perspectives reveal the 'truth' behind the growth ideology or, at least, free us from the shackles of growth thinking (Jackson 169, 192; Latouche 9, 13; Victor 220, 217). The growth ideology is also pictured as irrational: metaphors, such as 'religion,' 'fetish' and 'obsession' are repeated throughout the books (e.g. Jackson 86, 99, 132, 188, 202; Latouche 3–4, 8, 16, 86; Victor 3). The authors present growth ideology as illogical by pointing out some inconsistencies between the growth ideology and economic theory. For example, Daly points out that the law of diminishing marginal utility is not applied to throughput growth (Daly in Jackson 268). What is more, the growth ideology is depicted as pathological since the society attempts to correct the problems caused by economic growth by further increasing the economy's size (Jackson 33, 88; Latouche 21).

There is also a neutral conceptualisation of ideology, which views ideologies as indispensable components of any collective understanding or action (Thompson 2011; van Dijk 2–8). Every group uses ideologies to legitimate and organize action and to maintain group cohesion (ibid.). It can be interpreted so that, according to the neutral conceptualization of ideology, one has no access to 'objective truth.' From this perspective, the books by Jackson, Victor and Latouche are also ideological. Thus, under the ideology theme, the opposition between growth and degrowth is a rivalry between two ideologies. All three authors state that the mission of their books is to stimulate discussion about the alternatives to economic growth (Jackson 172, 187; Latouche 96; Victor 3). However, the books are not neutral but try to lead

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

1 this conversation into a certain direction. This is not to say, that they are trying to dictate the
2 alternative of growth, merely that they propose and establish some guidelines.

3 The alternative ideology offered by the growth critics brings economic growth down
4 from its pedestal. Daly summarises this demystifying fittingly in the commentary of Jackson's
5 book (267): 'The fundamental axiom of growth, rigorously stated by Kenneth Boulding, is that
6 "When something grows, it gets bigger!" When the economy grows it too gets bigger.' In the
7 degrowth ideology growth is not automatically considered good. Instead, one has to look at its
8 consequences for the society and nature before arriving to a conclusion.

9 The degrowth or agrowth ideology has a different set of values: social and ecological
10 perspectives take priority over economic values (Jackson 122; Latouche 34–5, 88), and
11 emphasis is laid on economy's connectedness to and dependence on the social and ecological
12 world. Interestingly, the authors do not elaborate, should either social or ecological
13 perspective take precedence over the other if they conflict. Nevertheless, the concepts of
14 profit and productivity would be reformulated in order to reflect the change in valuations
15 (Jackson 140–2, 176–7). The reversed priorities are also reflected in the way sustainability is
16 portrayed: sustainability requires that Western countries abandon economic growth.

17 Alongside the shift from economic interests to overall sustainability, a better balance
18 between short-term and long-term perspectives is also promoted (Latouche 31, 94; Jackson
19 32–33, 46, 140–1, 160, 192; Victor 217–8). In this way, intergenerational equity would be
20 better accounted for in the decision-making. In addition, equality between and within nations
21 is emphasised (Jackson 41; Latouche 23–5, 28, 37, 56–65; Victor 18, 24–5, 98). Latouche (37–8,
22 43–52) also promotes locality. Well-being, too, is defined in a different way under the
23 degrowth ideology (especially Jackson scrutinises this subject 16, 36, 43–47, 147–148, 189–90).

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of the 21st century growth critique

Well-being is based on a limited number of satiable needs (not insatiable wants). Standard of living is only one part of well-being and people are encouraged to act outside the consumer role in order to satisfy their needs for social relationships and meaningful life (ibid.; see also Latouche 40–1, 70, 85–6). The content analysis of the ideology theme is summarised in Table 3.

Table 3. Key elements of the ideology theme are summarised in the table. The first stage of analysis is on the left column, the second stage in the centre and the final stage on right.

Condensed meaning	Category	Theme
Equating economic growth with well-being, equating absence of economic growth with catastrophe	Beliefs and values related to economic growth	Economic growth as an ideology
Economy as a sphere separate from nature and society		
Economic values take priority in decision-making		
Economic growth is taken for granted and treated as natural	Hegemonic status of economic growth	
Presenting economic growth as the only alternative, limiting imagination	Misleading and distorting 'the reality'	
Inconsistencies and irrationality of the growth logic		

6 Summary and Discussion

Growth critique is essentially a critique of contemporary societies. Seeing growth as a phenomenon, an institution and an ideology provides a new framework for understanding the diverse aspects of (de)growth, each offering a different perspective on growth and its critique. The main findings of the analysis are summarised in Table 4.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology: A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

16 **Table 4. The main findings of this study are summarised in the table.**

		THEMES		
		PHENOMENON	INSTITUTION	IDEOLOGY
What meanings are attached to economic growth?		Economic growth is a phenomenon that has concrete effects on the environment and well-being.	Economic growth is an institution that directs the choices people make. Societies are founded on economic growth and thus have become dependent on it. Accordingly, culture has taken the shape of consumer culture that supports economic growth.	Economic growth is an ideology affecting people's values and worldviews. It also narrows down people's ability to see alternatives for economic growth. The growth ideology has reached a hegemonic position.
Book that most thoroughly examines the theme		Victor 2008	Jackson 2009	Latouche 2009
What kind of forms does the opposition between advocates and opponents of growth take?		Opposing interpretations of empirical evidence concerning the effects of economic growth.	Reformists supporting change within current institutions vs. radicals demanding replacement of the institutions themselves.	Hegemonic ideology vs. marginal ideology.
Pro-growth	(Alleged) main argument	Economic growth fosters and creates well-being all around the world. Economic growth and environmental protection can be combined effectively.	Since societies are dependent on economic growth, growth cannot be discarded. The idea of degrowth is irresponsible and has no connection to societal reality.	Economic growth is the source of all good things and as indispensable as the natural laws. Critics of economic growth are irrational.
	(Supposed) proposition	Green economic growth will resolve environmental issues and create more well-being.	Ecological integrity and well-being should be aspired only within the limits permitted by the pursuit of economic growth.	A world view and a set of values centred on economy and economic growth.
Degrowth	Main argument	The harm caused by economic growth outweighs its benefits (in the Western countries). Adequate reductions of negative environmental effects are not likely to be achieved while growing the economy.	Consequences of abandoning economic growth depend on the setting in which the change is implemented.	Economic growth and well-being cannot be equated. Questioning and dismantling the growth ideology opens up new possibilities. Advocates of growth are blinded by their ideology.
	Option	Explicit well-being and environmental goals, indifferent attitude towards economic growth.	Building a society independent of economic growth. Institutions and practices supporting economic growth should be replaced with new ones.	A worldview and a set of values based on combining social and ecological perspectives. The economic perspective is secondary.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

Although the themes are treated separately in this analysis, there is some overlap between them. The ideological nature of growth critique has an effect on how growth is described as a phenomenon or as an institution. On the other hand, analysing growth related phenomena and institutions offers arguments for questioning the growth ideology.

All three books deal with all three themes, but each book emphasises them differently. In Victor's book, growth as a phenomenon is the strongest theme, whereas in Jackson's book growth as an institution has a more significant role, and Latouche emphasises growth as an ideology. The books complement each other and together they offer a versatile view on the 21st century growth critique. The line of thought is quite similar in all three books, albeit each of them has unique features as well. Since the books lean on and draw from earlier and contemporary references critical to economic growth, the three themes could be used in analysing and understanding growth critique in general. However, when applied to other texts, new categories or themes not covered in this analysis might emerge. For example, these books do not elaborate on the role of physical structures, such as technology and infrastructure, in narrowing down one's options to behave differently and locking societies in current unsustainable practices (see Sanne 2002). Nevertheless, this particular idea could be integrated with the institution theme, because, according to Scott (2008: 127), the material world and social institutions form a mutually reinforcing system.

What is more, the themes identified in this study could also be applied in studying the implementation of the degrowth vision: What concrete consequences would it have? What kind of institutions would it give rise to? What kind of ideology would be it based upon?

There is a different kind of opposition between advocates and opponents of growth under each theme. The parties to this dispute do not stand on an equal ground, since

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

1 economic growth has a hegemonic position. The material gives an impression that the growth
2 critics are more capable of describing what they oppose than what they actually favour.
3 Perhaps this explains why the degrowth vision remains somewhat abstract and obscure.
4 Furthermore, the growth critics use a lot of time and effort to show they are aware of the pro-
5 growth arguments, implying that even growth critique is still entangled in the hegemonic
6 discourse. The authors aim to show that economic growth is as crazy and idealistic as
7 degrowth, and, in that way, they attempt to undermine its hegemonic position. It seems that it
8 is much easier to prove that growth religion is an ideology than it is to weaken its power. After
9 all, the material is more successful in describing the logic of growth – even if in an
10 unfavourable light – than in building a clear and tangible alternative for it. What is more,
11 unfortunately, the current degrowth debate is a little too much like a monologue. A more
12 reciprocal discussion with the advocates of growth might stimulate a more rapid shift away
13 from the growth society, or third way alternatives.

14 One of the main findings of this study is that on the level of concrete phenomena, it is
15 not fruitful to examine economic growth as a whole since it has both negative and positive
16 effects. The books neither represent a reductionist ‘growth bad, absence of growth good’
17 thinking nor promote the opposite of growth logic, that is, continual downsizing of the
18 economy. Instead, they seem to promote selectivity (that is, downsizing actions that have
19 negative effects on the environment and/or well-being, and growing or at least maintaining
20 actions with positive effects). Under the phenomenon theme, the books also suggest
21 indifference towards economic growth, that is, agrowth. Ironically, it is unclear whether the
22 messages are heard, since the books still focus quite intensely on economic growth. This is due
23 to fact that under the two other themes the approach of the books is everything but
24 nonchalant since dismantling of the institutions and ideology of growth will hardly be achieved

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

without intentional resistance. Thus, the institution and ideology themes of the books promote degrowth. The discussion above reveals a paradox within growth critique and offers new insights into the debate over agrowth and degrowth. Perhaps it would be fruitful to consider these two approaches as successive phases: deliberate degrowth thinking might be needed at first in order to reach – as a society – the agrowth attitude.

In an earlier study, the authors of this article have concluded that the idea of sufficiency both questions the equation of economic growth with well-being and promotes the distinction of means and ends (Schultz and Tapio 2011). The same line of thought can be seen in the research material of this paper. The books claim that, according to conventional growth logic, economic growth has transformed from a means into an end. Growth seems to be the ultimate goal of modern societies and also a way to achieve any other valuable objective. The books criticise this confusion of means and ends and attempt to restore the place of economic growth as one means among many others.

If growth and degrowth are considered as means, it seems that both growth advocates and opponents should describe more clearly how the alleged mechanisms of economic growth or degrowth actually affect the quality of environment or the quality of life. Investigating these causal chains would provide new insights into the relevance of economic growth and degrowth as impediments or requirements of ecological and social sustainability.

Acknowledgements. A draft of this paper was presented at the ESEE 2013 conference, in session ‘Capitalism, Green Growth and Degrowth.’ We would like to thank all session participants for their comments and encouragement. We are grateful for insightful comments of the editor and anonymous reviewers, which helped to broaden our analysis and sharpen our

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

arguments. Special thanks belong to Risto Willamo for fruitful conversations and support during the research process. The Academy of Finland is acknowledged for partial research funding of the work (Research Grants 128307 and 263464).

References

- Alcott, Blake 2010: Impact caps: Why population, affluence and technology strategies should be abandoned. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 18(6), 552–560.
- Alcott, Blake 2008: The sufficiency strategy: Would rich-world frugality lower environmental impact? *Ecological Economics*, 64(4), 770–786.
- Alfredsson, Eva 2004: ‘Green’ consumption—no solution for climate change. *Energy*, 29 (4), 513–524.
- Ang, Beng Wah and Liu, N., 2006: A cross-country analysis of aggregate energy and carbon intensities. *Energy Policy*, 34 (15), 2398–2404.
- Arndt, Heinz Wolfgang 1978: *The Rise and Fall of Economic Growth. A Study in Contemporary Thought*. Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press.
- Ayres, Robert 2008: Sustainability economics: Where do we stand? *Ecological Economics*, 67 (2), 281–310.
- Baran, Paul A. and Sweezy, Paul M. 1966: *Monopoly Capital. An essay on the American economic and Social Order*. New York: Monthly Review.
- Berkhout, Peter; Muskens, Jos and Velthuisen, Jan 2000: Defining the rebound effect. *Energy Policy*, 28 (6–7), 425–432.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 Binswanger, Mathias 2001: Technological progress and sustainable development: What about
2 the rebound effect? *Ecological Economics*, 36 (1), 119–132.
- 3 Bithas, Kostas and Kalimeris, Panos 2013: Re-estimating the decoupling effect: Is there an
4 actual transition towards a less energy-intensive economy? *Energy*, 51, 78–84.
- 5 Boulding, Kenneth 1968: Economics of the coming spaceship Earth. In Jarret, Henry (ed.):
6 Environmental quality in a growing economy. Essays for the sixth RFF Forum. Baltimore: John
7 Hopkins Press. pp 3–14.
- 8 Carruthers, David 2001: From opposition to orthodoxy: The remaking of sustainable
9 development. *Journal of Third World Studies*, 18 (2), 93–112.
- 10 Collins, Robert M. 2002: More. The Politics of Economic Growth in Postwar America. New York:
11 Oxford University Press.
- 12 D’Alisa, Giacomo and Cattaneo, Claudio 2013: Household work and energy consumption: a
13 degrowth perspective. Catalonia’s case study. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 38, 71–79
- 14 Daly, Herman 1997: Georgescu-Roegen versus Solow/Stiglitz. *Ecological Economics* 22: 261–
15 266.
- 16 Daly, Herman 1996: Beyond growth: The economics of sustainable development Boston:
17 Beacon Press.
- 18 Daly, Herman 1991: Steady-state economics. Washington, D.C.: Island Press.
- 19 Daly, Herman 1974: Steady-state economics versus growthmania: A critique of the orthodox
20 conceptions of growth, wants, scarcity, and efficiency. *Policy Sciences*, 5 (2), 149–167.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- Daly, Herman and Cobb, John B. Jr 1989: For the Common Good: Redirecting the Economy
Toward Community, the Environment and a Sustainable Future. Boston: Beacon Press.
- Demaria, Frederico; Schneider, François; Sekulova, Filka and Martínez-Alier, Joan 2013: What is
Degrowth? From an Activist Slogan to a Social Movement. *Environmental Values*, 22 (2), 191–
215.
- van Dijk, Teun 1998: *Ideology. A Multidisciplinary Approach*. London: Sage.
- Easterlin, Richard 1974: Does economic growth improve the human lot? In David Paul and
Reder Melvin (eds.): *Nations and Households in Economic Growth: Essays in honor of Moses
Abramovitz*. New York: Academic Press, pp. 89–125.
- Elo, Satu and Kyngäs, Helvi 2008: The qualitative content analysis process. *Advanced Nursing*,
62 (1), 107–115.
- European Commission 2011: Rio+20: towards the green economy and better governance.
http://ec.europa.eu/environment/international_issues/pdf/rio/com_2011_363_en.pdf
Retrieved January 19, 2012.
- Figge, Frank; Young, William and Barkemeyer, Ralf 2014: Sufficiency or efficiency to achieve
lower resource consumption and emissions? The role of the rebound effect. *Journal of Cleaner
Production*, 69, 216–224.
- Forman, Jane and Damschroder, Laura 2008: Qualitative content Analysis. In Jacoby, Liva and
Siminoff, Laura (eds.) *Empirical Methods for Bioethics: A Primer*. *Advances in Bioethics* 11. pp.
39–62. Amsterdam: Elsevier.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 Fournier, Valérie 2008: Escaping from the economy: The politics of degrowth. International
2 Journal of Sociology and Social Policy, 28 (11–12), 528–545.
- 3 Fuchs, Doris and Lorek, Sylvia 2005: Sustainable Consumption Governance: A History of
4 Promises and Failures. Journal of Consumer Policy, 28 (3), 261–288.
- 5 Gabriel, Yiannis and Lang, Tim 1995: The Unmanageable Consumer. Contemporary
6 Consumption and its Fragmentations. London: Sage.
- 7 Galbraith, John Kenneth 1958: The Affluent Society. London: Hamish Hamilton.
- 8 Georgescu-Roegen, Nicholas 1971: The entropy law and the economic process. Cambridge:
9 Harvard University Press.
- 10 Giannetti, Biagio; Agostinho, Feni; Almeida, Cecília and Huisingh, Donald 2015: A review of
11 limitations of GDP and alternative indices to monitor human wellbeing and to manage eco-
12 system functionality. Journal of Cleaner Production, 87, 11–25.
- 13 Graneheim, Ulla and Lundman, Berit 2004: Qualitative content analysis in nursing research:
14 concepts, procedures and measures to achieve trustworthiness. Nurse Education Today, 24 (2),
15 105–112.
- 16 Greening, Lorna; Greene, David and Difiglio, Carmen 2000: Energy efficiency and consumption
17 — the rebound effect — a survey. Energy Policy, 28 (6–7), 389–401.
- 18 Hirsch, Fred 1977: Social limits to growth. London: Routledge & Kegan.
- 19 Hoffman, Ulrich 2011: Some Reflections on Climate Change, Green Growth Illusions and
20 Development Space. UNCTAD Discussion papers, no. 205. United Nations Conference on Trade

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

and Development: http://unctad.org/en/PublicationsLibrary/osgdp2011d5_en.pdf. Retrieved

July 10, 2015.

Jackson, Tim 2009: Prosperity without growth: economics for a finite planet. London:

Earthscan.

Johanisova, Nadia; Crabtree, Tim and Fraňková, Eva 2013: Social enterprises and non-market

capitals: a path to degrowth? Journal of Cleaner Production, 38, 7–16.

Kallis, Giorgos 2011: In defence of degrowth. Ecological Economics, 70 (5), 873–880.

Kapp, Karl William 1975: The social costs of private enterprise. The 1971 edition. New York:

Schocken Books.

Kerschner, Christian 2010: Economic de-growth vs. steady-state economy. Journal of Cleaner

Production, 18 (6), 544–551.

Latouche, Serge 2009: Farewell to growth. Translated by David Macey. Cambridge: Polity Press.

Malthus, Thomas Robert 1976: An Essay of the Principle of Population: Text, Sources and

Background, Criticism, (ed. by P. Appleman). New York: W.W. Norton & Company Inc.

Martínez-Alier, Joan; Pascual, Unai; Franck-Dominique, Vivien and Zaccai, Edwin 2010:

Sustainable de-growth: Mapping the context, criticisms and future prospects of an emergent

paradigm. Ecological economics, 69 (9), 1741–1747.

Matthey, Astrid 2010: Less is more: The influence of aspirations and priming on well-being.

Journal of Cleaner Production, 18 (6), 567–570.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 Max-Neef, Manfred 1995: Economic growth and quality of life: a threshold hypothesis.
2 Ecological economics, 15 (2), 115–118.
- 3 McCracken, Grant 1988: Culture and consumption new approaches to the symbolic character
4 of consumer goods and activities. Bloomington: Indiana University Press.
- 5 McLellan David, 1995: Ideology. 2nd edition. Buckingham: Open University Press.
- 6 Meadows, Donella; Meadows, Dennis and Randers, Jorgen 2004: The Limits to Growth. The 30-
7 year update. White River Junction (Vermont, US): Chelsea Green.
- 8 Meadows, Donella; Meadows, Dennis and Randers, Jørgen 1992: Beyond the Limits.
9 Confronting Global Collapse, Envisioning a Sustainable Future. White River Junction (Vermont,
10 US): Chelsea Green.
- 11 Meadows, Donella; Meadows, Dennis; Randers, Jørgen and Behrens, William 1972: The Limits
12 to Growth: A report for the Club of Rome's project on the predicament of mankind. London:
13 Earth Island.
- 14 Mebratu, Desta 1998: Sustainability and sustainable development: Historical and conceptual
15 review. Environmental Impact Assessment Review, 18 (6), 493–520.
- 16 Mitcham, Carl 1995: The concept of sustainable development: its origins and ambivalence.
17 Technology in Society, 17 (3), 311–326.
- 18 Munasinghe, Mohan 1996: An overview of the environmental impacts of macroeconomic and
19 sectoral policies. In Munasinghe, M. (ed.), Environmental Impacts of Macroeconomic and
20 Sectoral Policies. Washington: The International Society for Ecological Economists, The World
21 Bank and The United Nations Environment Programme, pp. 1–14.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 Nørgård, Jørgen 2013: Happy degrowth through more amateur economy. *Journal of Cleaner*
2 *Production*, 38, 61–70.
- 3 OECD 2011: Towards Green Growth. <http://www.oecd.org/dataoecd/37/34/48224539.pdf>.
4 Retrieved January 19, 2012.
- 5 Ostrom, Elinor 2005: Understanding institutional diversity. Princeton and Oxford: Princeton
6 University Press.
- 7 Peters, Glen; Minx, Jan; Weber, Christopher and Edenhofer, Ottmar 2011: Growth in emission
8 transfers via international trade from 1990 to 2008. *PNAS*, 108 (21), 8903–8.
- 9 Pigou, Arthur Cecil 1932: *The Economics of Welfare*. 4th edition, London, MacMillan. Available
10 at [www.econlib.org/library/NPDBooks/Pigou/pgEW20.html#Part II, Chapter 9](http://www.econlib.org/library/NPDBooks/Pigou/pgEW20.html#Part%20II,Chapter%209). Retrieved
11 December 8, 2011.
- 12 Røpke, Inge 2004: The early history of modern ecological economics. *Ecological Economics*, 50
13 (3–4), 293–314.
- 14 Røpke, Inge 1999: The dynamics of willingness to consume. *Ecological Economics*, 28(3), 399–
15 420.
- 16 Sahlins, Marshall 2004: *Stone Age Economics*. London: Routledge.
- 17 Sanne, Christer 2002: Willing consumers – or locked in? Politics for sustainable consumption.
18 *Ecological Economics*, 42 (1–2), 237–287.
- 19 Schneider, François 2008: Macroscopic Rebound Effects as argument for economic degrowth.
20 In Flipo, Fabrice and Schneider, François 2008: *Proceedings of the First Economic Degrowth for*
21 *Ecological Sustainability and Social Equity*. Paris 18–19 April, 2008, p. 29–36. <http://events.it->

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 [sudparis.eu/degrowthconference/en/appe/Degrowth%20Conference%20-](http://sudparis.eu/degrowthconference/en/appe/Degrowth%20Conference%20-%20Proceedings.pdf)
2 [%20Proceedings.pdf](http://sudparis.eu/degrowthconference/en/appe/Degrowth%20Conference%20-%20Proceedings.pdf). Retrieved April 28, 2013.
- 3 Schneider, François; Kallis Giorgos and Martínez-Alier, Joan 2010: Crisis or opportunity?
4 Economic degrowth for social equity and ecological sustainability. Introduction to this special
5 issue. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 18 (6), 511–518.
- 6 Schor, Juliet 2005: *Prices and quantities: Unsustainable consumption and the global economy*.
7 *Ecological Economics*, 55 (3), 309–320.
- 8 Schor, Juliet 2004: *Born to Buy: the commercialized child and the new consumer culture*. New
9 York: Scribner.
- 10 Schor, Juliet 1999: *The Overspent American. Why We Want What We Don't Need*. New York:
11 Harper Perennial.
- 12 Schor, Juliet 1993: *The Overworked American. The Unexpected Decline of Leisure*. New York:
13 Basic Books.
- 14 Schultz, Liisa and Tapio, Petri 2011: Kulutuskriittinen kohtuullisuus tarveteorioiden valossa.
15 [The sufficiency strategy of consumption in the light of need theories.] *Alue ja ympäristö*, 40
16 (1), 3–16.
- 17 Scitovski, Tibor 1977: *The joyless economy: An inquiry into human satisfaction and consumer*
18 *dissatisfaction*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- 19 Scott, W. Richard 2008: *Institutions and Organizations. Ideas and Interests*. 3rd edition. Los
20 Angeles: Sage.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

Solow, Robert M. 1997: Reply. Georgescu-Roegen versus Solow/Stiglitz. *Ecological Economics*

22(3): 267–268.

Spangenberg, Joachim 2010: The Growth Discourse, Growth Policy and Sustainable

Development: Two Thought Experiments. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 18 (6), 561–566.

Stiglitz, Joseph E. 1997: Reply. Georgescu-Roegen versus Solow/Stiglitz. *Ecological Economics*

22(3): 269–270.

Tapio, Petri 2005: Towards a theory of decoupling: Degrees of decoupling in the EU and the

case of road traffic in Finland between 1970 and 2001. *Transport Policy*, 12(2), 137–151.

Thompson, John Brookshire 2001: Ideology: history of the concept. In Smelser, Neil and Baltes,

Paul (eds.): *International Encyclopaedia of the Social and Behavioral Sciences*. Volume 11.

Amsterdam, Elsevier. pp. 7170–4.

UN 1993: Earth Summit: Agenda 21 – The United Nations Programme of action from Rio. UN.

<http://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/content/documents/Agenda21.pdf>. Retrieved April 3,

2013.

UNEP 2011: Towards a Green Economy: Pathways to Sustainable Development and Poverty

Eradication.

[http://www.unep.org/greeneconomy/Portals/88/documents/ger/ger_final_dec_2011/Green%](http://www.unep.org/greeneconomy/Portals/88/documents/ger/ger_final_dec_2011/Green%20EconomyReport_Final_Dec2011.pdf)

[20EconomyReport_Final_Dec2011.pdf](http://www.unep.org/greeneconomy/Portals/88/documents/ger/ger_final_dec_2011/Green%20EconomyReport_Final_Dec2011.pdf). Retrieved January 19, 2012.

van den Bergh, Jeroen 2011: Environment versus growth — A criticism of ‘degrowth’ and a

plea for ‘a-growth’. *Ecological Economics*, 70 (5), 881–890.

Economic growth as phenomenon, institution and ideology:
A qualitative content analysis of 21st century growth critique

- 1 van den Bergh, Jeroen 2010: Relax about GDP growth: Implications for climate and crisis
2 policies. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 18 (6), 540–543.
- 3 van den Bergh, Jeroen 2009: The GDP paradox. *Journal of Economic Psychology*, 30 (2), 117–
4 135.
- 5 van den Bergh, Jeroen and Kallis, Giorgos 2012: Growth, A-Growth or Degrowth to Stay within
6 Planetary Boundaries? *Journal of Economic Issues*, 46 (4), 909–919.
- 7 van Griethuysen, Pascal 2010: Why are we growth-addicted? The hard way towards degrowth
8 in the involutory western development path. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 18 (6), 590–
9 595.
- 10 Vatn, Arild 2005: *Institutions and the Environment*. Cheltenham and Northampton: Edward
11 Elgar.
- 12 Veblen, Thorstein 1992: *The theory of the leisure class. An economic study of institution*. New
13 Brunswick: Transaction Publishers.
- 14 Victor, Peter 2008: *Managing without growth: Slower by design, not disaster*. Cheltenham:
15 Edward Elgar.
- 16 Waggoner, Paul and Ausubel, Jesse 2002: A framework for sustainability: A renovated IPAT
17 identity. *PNAS*, 99 (12), 7860–7865.
- 18 WCED 1987: *Our Common Future*. Oxford and New York: Oxford University Press.
- 19 York, Richard; Rosa, Eugene and Dietz, Thomas 2003: STIRPAT, IPAT and ImPACT: Analytic tools
20 for unpacking the driving forces of environmental impacts. *Ecological Economics*, 46 (3), 351–
21 365.